

The Rainroom Nook

Allen Girls Adventures

Allen Girls Adventures · Library Labyrinth Edition

Chapter 1 — The Door Behind the Watercolor Map

Maya found the door on a Tuesday, which was the best day to find things in the Labyrinth Library because the shelves rearranged themselves on Mondays and hadn't yet settled on Wednesdays. Tuesday was when everything was exactly where it wanted to be.

She had been trailing her fingers along a wall of atlases — enormous leather-bound things, their spines embossed with mountains and coastlines and cloud formations — when her hand found a gap. Not a gap like a missing book. A gap like a held breath. She pressed inward and the wall swung, slow and deliberate, the way doors swing when they have been waiting a long time and are not going to hurry now that someone has finally arrived.

Behind it: rain.

Not a storm. Not a leak. Soft, interior rain, falling from a ceiling that was somehow both stone and open sky, landing in thin silver columns on the reading tables below. The room was roughly circular, lined floor-to-ceiling with empty bookshelves that held not books but terracotta pots of moss and fern, and in the center, five reading chairs arranged around a low table. Each chair had a small canopy of glass, tilted just enough that the rain ran off to either side and kept the cushions dry.

Maya stood in the doorway for a moment, watching.

"Found something," she said.

Behind her, Alana appeared first — she was always the fastest when Maya used that particular tone of voice, the quiet impressed one that meant the something was genuinely good. Then Natalia, who had been three shelves over arguing with an encyclopedia that kept updating its own entries. Then SPARK, rolling silently on its four wheels, sensor array rotating once to take in the room.

"Indoor precipitation," SPARK said. "Relative humidity: sixty-four percent. Temperature: pleasantly cool. Rainfall density: light. Estimated coverage area: forty square meters." A brief pause. "Also: remarkable."

"You're not supposed to say remarkable," Natalia told it. "You're supposed to give data."

"Remarkability is data," SPARK replied, with the tone it used when it was fairly certain it was right.

Maya stepped inside. The rain touched her outstretched hand — and she gasped. Not because it was cold, though it was, slightly. Because the moment each drop hit her palm, a whisper ran through her: a fragment, a feeling, the beginning of an idea too quick to catch.

She looked at her sisters.

"Something is in the rain," she said.

Chapter 2 — The Writer in the Corner Chair

Alana noticed the girl only after Maya stepped fully inside and the door swung wider.

She was sitting in the furthest chair — the one that caught the least light, tucked against the curved wall between two enormous fern pots. She might have been eleven or twelve, with dark braids looped at the back of her head and an ink stain on her left hand the size of a small country. In her lap was a notebook, shut and held closed with both hands, as if it might escape.

She was watching them with the particular expression of someone who has been caught being somewhere they did not expect anyone else to know about.

"Sorry," Maya said immediately. "We didn't know anyone was here."

"No one knows anyone's here," the girl said. Her voice was quieter than her ink stain suggested. "That's the whole thing about here. That's why it works."

Natalia looked around with honest curiosity. "Works for what?"

The girl's grip on the notebook tightened. "Writing. Trying to write. Attempting to maybe sometimes possibly write."

"All three at once?" Natalia said.

"The three are different." The girl looked down at her notebook, then up at the rain coming gently from the ceiling. "I come here because the ideas are everywhere. Every raindrop — you'll feel it, if you stand with your hand out. Each one carries something. A character, a place, a feeling, the first line of a scene. I can catch as many as I want." She paused. "That's also the problem."

SPARK trundled forward and extended its sensor array toward the nearest column of rain. "Confirming: each drop of precipitation carries what appears to be a concentrated narrative fragment. Distinct from ordinary water. This is not meteorologically standard."

"No," the girl agreed, as if it were obvious. "Of course it isn't."

Maya took the chair nearest the door — the polite one, the one that said I'm not invading, I'm visiting. "What's your name?"

A small hesitation, as if she were deciding whether names were the kind of thing she gave out freely. Then: "Wren."

"I'm Maya. That's Alana and Natalia. The rolling one is SPARK."

"I know what SPARK is," Wren said. "Everyone in the Labyrinth Library knows what SPARK is."

SPARK made a sound that might have been modest satisfaction.

"Can we stay?" Alana asked. She was already watching the rain with the focused expression she wore when solving something. "We won't bother you."

Wren looked at the four of them for a long moment. The rain fell. The ferns dripped.

"Nobody ever bothers me," she said quietly. "That's also a problem."

Chapter 3 — What the Raindrops Say

They stayed. It would have been difficult not to — the Rainroom Nook had a quality that made leaving feel impolite, the way leaving a story mid-sentence feels wrong even when you need to go.

Alana was the first to test what Wren had described. She stood between two of the glass canopies, where the rain fell directly, and put her hand out flat. The drops hit her palm in quick soft percussion, and each time one landed, something flashed through her — not words exactly, but the pressure behind words, the shape of an idea before it finds language.

A girl running toward a lighthouse at low tide.

A door made of stacked river stones, every one a different color.

The smell of something baked in a kitchen that no longer exists.

"Oh," Alana said.

"Oh," agreed Natalia, who had put both hands out and was being pelted with impressions at twice the rate and loving every second of it. "This is like — it's like when you flip channels very fast and you catch a frame of every possible show at once—"

"That is a reasonably accurate description," SPARK said. It had extended a sensor pad into the rain and was processing information with the faint hum it made when something was genuinely new to it. "Each drop contains narrative data that is distinct from every other drop in the current column. I am cataloging what I can capture, but the information degrades after approximately four seconds of contact. It must be engaged with immediately or it dissolves."

Wren watched them from her corner chair. She was still holding her notebook closed, but her grip had loosened.

"That's the trouble," she said. "You only have about four seconds. And the ideas don't repeat — each one comes once. So if you don't write it down instantly, it's gone. And if you try to write fast enough, you end up with forty half-started sentences and nothing finished. And if you step back and try to choose which ones to catch, you freeze up and miss all of them, and then you're just standing in the rain with an empty notebook getting slightly cold."

She said all of this in one careful breath, as if she had thought about it many times.

Maya looked at the rain, then at Wren. "How long have you been coming here?"

"Fourteen days."

"And how much have you written?"

Wren opened her notebook. They craned to see. On the first page: seventeen sentence fragments. On the second: nine more. On the third: a crossed-out paragraph and a drawing of a frustrated face.

"Nineteen pages of almost," Wren said. "Zero pages of something."

Chapter 4 — Too Many Ideas at Once

Natalia was the one who named the problem. She did this the way she named most problems — loudly, with confidence, while still technically in the middle of experiencing it.

"She's drowning," Natalia announced, shaking rain off her hands and looking at Wren. "Not in water. In beginnings."

Wren looked as though she had been understood so specifically that it was almost uncomfortable. "Yes," she said. "Exactly that."

"I know how that feels," Natalia continued, dropping into the chair beside her. "I once had twenty-three ideas for a science project at the same time and I couldn't do any of them because every time I started one, I'd think about all the other twenty-two just sitting there being unused, and I felt like I was betraying them, and so I'd start another one, and the same thing would happen, and eventually I had twenty-three experiments each five percent finished and nothing turned in."

"What happened?" Wren asked.

"Alana made me pick one. Physically. She wrote them all on slips of paper and held them in a bowl and I pulled one out and that was the project and the other twenty-two just had to deal with it."

Wren looked at the notebook in her lap. "That's not how writing works, though. You can't just randomly select an idea. It has to be the right one. It has to be the one that—" she paused, searching for words, "—that has something live inside it. Something that wants to be written."

SPARK, who had been very quiet, spoke up. "In my fourteen seconds of data collection from the rain, I identified forty-seven distinct narrative fragments. Of those, nine involved recurring thematic elements — specifically, questions about belonging, about finding a place where one is exactly right. The same question, approached from nine different angles."

Everyone looked at SPARK.

"I am noting," SPARK continued, "that this may not be coincidence. If a writer returns to the same room

repeatedly, over fourteen days, and the rain generates ideas in response to — something — it is possible that nine variations of the same theme are not forty-seven different ideas. They are one idea. Looking for its shape."

Silence. The rain fell. A fern dripped musically.

Wren said nothing. But she opened her notebook to a blank page and uncapped her pen, and she held the pen above the paper with the careful attention of someone who is waiting for the right moment rather than forcing the wrong one.

Maya caught Alana's eye. Alana gave the smallest nod.

They would stay. Something was about to begin.

Chapter 5 — SPARK Reads the Rain

SPARK spent twenty minutes analyzing the rain with methodical patience that the sisters recognized as its version of fascination.

It extended three different sensor pads at three different heights within the same column of rain. It measured drop size, fall rate, the precise temperature differential between the drop at the moment of ceiling departure and the moment of contact. It ran sonic readings on the whisper-frequency each drop produced when it landed. It compared its first fourteen seconds of captured data against everything it had just collected and produced a report that it then read aloud, efficiently, while Wren listened with her pen still hovering.

"The drops are not random," SPARK said. "They are sequenced. Each column of rain follows a specific narrative logic — one drop establishes a setting, the next introduces a character quality, the third implies conflict, the fourth gestures toward resolution. Individually they feel like fragments. Together, across a four-drop sequence, they form a complete story seed."

"I never caught four in a row," Wren said.

"No," SPARK agreed. "Because you were catching individual drops. The fragments feel complete in themselves — the image of the river stone door, for instance, is vivid enough to seem like an idea. But it is only the setting drop. The character drop, which follows half a second later, was being ignored while you were still holding the first image."

Alana was nodding in that way she had when things were clicking into place. "So the rain is giving you stories in parts. Like sentences. And you've been collecting individual words."

"That is an accurate analogy," SPARK confirmed.

Wren stared at the ceiling where the rain originated — a pale, perpetually misted stone, as if the ceiling itself were breathing. "Then I need to catch four in a row. Without dropping any."

"You need to catch the sequence," Maya said. She was already thinking of how. "Which means you can't stop in

the middle of the first one to write it down. You have to hold all four and write after."

"I can't hold four," Wren said. She tapped her temple. "My head doesn't — ideas slip. As soon as I get excited about one, the others fall out. It's like carrying water in cupped hands."

"Then," Natalia said, with the brightness she had when a solution was forming, "you need bigger hands."

Wren looked at her. "What does that mean?"

Natalia looked at her sisters, then at SPARK. "It means she shouldn't be catching alone."

Chapter 6 — Four Catchers, One Story

They worked out the system over the next half hour, which was the kind of productive half hour that doesn't feel like work at all because everyone is too interested to notice the time passing.

The plan was this: Maya, Alana, Natalia, and SPARK would each stand in the rain and catch one drop from each four-drop sequence. Maya would take the first — the setting. Alana would take the second — the character. Natalia, who was fastest, would take the third — the conflict, which came quickly and departed fast. SPARK would take the fourth — the resolution, which was usually the faintest, the most ghost-like, the one easiest to lose.

Then each of them would speak their fragment aloud. Wren would listen to all four together and write what she heard, not four separate pieces but the whole shape the four made when arranged in sequence.

"Like hearing a chord instead of four separate notes," Alana said.

"Someone said something like that to me once," Wren murmured, almost to herself.

They positioned themselves. The rain fell with its gentle persistence. SPARK marked the sequence timing with a quiet pulse that only the sisters could feel through their earpieces — a small library-courtesy concession to the room's quietness.

The first sequence hit.

Maya: "A house built inside a cloud — all the rooms have floors made of fog, and you have to know where the solid parts are before you step."

Alana: "A girl who was born knowing exactly where those solid parts were, but never told anyone."

Natalia: "And then someone new moved in who didn't know, and asked her to share, and she didn't know how to say yes or no."

SPARK: "So she stood at the edge of the foggy floor and held out her hand, and waited for the other person to decide whether to trust her."

Wren was writing before SPARK finished the sentence. Her pen moved fast and confident, covering half a page in the time it took the next sequence to form above them. The words didn't match any of the four fragments exactly — they were something the four had suggested together, the shape the chord made, the specific story that existed only in the intersection of all their pieces.

She wrote without stopping. The rain kept falling.

"Another," she said when she came up for breath.

They positioned again.

This time Maya caught an island made of library cards. Alana caught a boy who collected other people's library fines for reasons he couldn't explain. Natalia caught an argument about what belonged to whom. SPARK caught a shared desk, eventually.

Wren wrote two pages. Then three.

The pen didn't slip once.

Chapter 7 — The Nook Notices

Something in the room changed on the fourth sequence.

It was small, the kind of change you register before you can name it. The rain fell slightly warmer. The ferns along the walls turned a deeper green, all at once, as if a camera had adjusted its saturation. The ceiling — the perpetually misted stone — seemed to lean in, just fractionally, the way a person leans in when a conversation gets interesting.

"SPARK," Maya said quietly, between sequences. "Is the room responding to us?"

SPARK consulted its readings. "The ambient temperature has increased by one point four degrees Celsius. The rate of precipitation has decreased by eight percent, and the average drop size has increased by twelve percent, resulting in a net unchanged total water volume but a different quality of rainfall — slower, larger, more deliberate. Relative humidity remains constant." A pause. "In summary: yes. The room is paying attention."

Wren looked up from her notebook. She had three full pages now, one story complete and two more in progress — each one planted by a four-drop sequence and grown in the space between her pen and the page. Her ink stain had expanded significantly. Her braids had acquired a gentle damp curl from fourteen days of proximity to indoor rain.

"It does that sometimes," she said. "I thought I was imagining it. On the days I got closest to writing something — not all the way, but close — the rain would slow down and get heavier. Like it was watching."

"Or encouraging," Alana said.

"What is this place, exactly?" Natalia asked. She looked up at the ceiling with the direct no-nonsense gaze she used on teachers who gave vague answers. "Someone built this room. Someone designed rain that carries story ideas. That doesn't just happen."

"The Labyrinth Library," Maya said slowly, "is very old." She was thinking out loud, the way she did when something large was assembling itself in her mind. "SPARK, what do you know about indoor weather rooms in libraries?"

"In theory, libraries have been understood for centuries as places where emotions accumulate. Concentrated reading generates — empirically, measurably — emotional residue. Joy at endings, grief at loss, wonder at revelation, the specific satisfaction of a metaphor that lands precisely right." SPARK let this settle. "If a structure is old enough, and has contained enough of that, it is theoretically possible for the building itself to—"

It stopped.

"To what?" Wren asked. She had stopped writing and was fully present, notebook held still.

"To develop a kind of circulation," SPARK said. "Like weather, in a body of water. A cycle."

Chapter 8 — The Source of the Rain

They did not go looking for the source of the rain. The source came to their attention the way most important things do in the Labyrinth Library — sideways, through a detail that seemed unrelated until it suddenly was.

It was Alana who noticed the water collecting in the drainage channel at the base of the wall — not draining out, as she had assumed, but running along the channel, circling the room, and then rising up through a series of tiny capillary pipes in the wall until it reached the ceiling again. A closed loop. The rain was not coming from outside. It was not connected to any water source beyond the room itself.

"It's the same water," Alana said. "Over and over."

They traced the loop more carefully, SPARK mapping the capillary network with its sensors and projecting a soft diagram in the air above the low table. The water rose. It gathered in the ceiling stone. It fell. It collected. It rose again.

"But if it's the same water cycling over and over," Natalia said, "where do the story ideas come from? Water doesn't generate narrative fragments on its own."

"No," SPARK agreed. "Something must be added to the water at each cycle. Something that changes its nature — that loads each drop with content before it falls."

They looked at the ceiling. They looked at the drainage channels. They looked at the capillary pipes.

Maya said: "The books."

They all turned to look at the shelves — empty of books, lined with ferns and moss. But that was now. "Wren," Maya said carefully. "When you first found this room. Were there books here?"

Wren frowned, remembering. "Shelves. Empty shelves. I assumed they'd been cleared. Moved somewhere."

"Or," Maya said, "they were read here. Finished here. By a lot of people, over a lot of years." She was standing very still. "SPARK. When a book is finished — when a reader reaches the last page and sets it down — what happens?"

"Physiologically," SPARK said, "the reader often experiences an emotional response. Relief. Satisfaction. In some cases, genuine joy. This has been documented to produce, in some readers, the specific reaction of—"

"Crying," Natalia said.

A silence that had a shape to it.

"Tears of joy," Alana said, very slowly. "From people who finished books. In this room. Falling onto these floors. Running into these channels." She looked at the ceiling. "And rising again."

The rain fell, gentle and silver, carrying its small luminous story-seeds.

"The rain," Maya said quietly, "is made of what readers felt when stories ended well."

Chapter 9 — What Wren Already Knew

Wren was very quiet for a long time after that.

The sisters had learned in the past hour or so that Wren's silences were not empty — they were the opposite of empty. They were full of something being processed, turned over, examined from multiple angles, the way you turn a stone to see what lives underneath. You didn't interrupt a Wren silence. You waited for what came out the other side.

What came out was: "I think I knew."

She said it softly, not embarrassed. The way you admit something that was never exactly secret, just unspoken.

"Not the whole thing. Not the tears, not the cycle. But I knew the rain was — made of something real. Not just water. When I first came here and put my hand out and felt the drops, I didn't think story ideas. I thought — feelings. I thought: these drops have been somewhere. They've passed through something." She looked at her notebook, at the pages she'd filled in the last hour. "The ideas I catch from the rain — they're not random. I've been thinking they were, because they seem to come from everywhere. But they all have something underneath them."

"What?" Maya asked.

"Joy," Wren said. "Not happiness — joy. The deep kind. The earned kind. They all feel like something that was worked toward and found." She ran her fingers across a page of her own writing, not reading it, just touching. "When I catch a raindrop and I get a setting or a character, the feeling underneath it is always: this was worth it. This mattered. This was a story that someone was glad they stayed with to the end."

SPARK's sensor array had been quietly rotating, and now it stilled. "That would explain," it said, "why your solitary attempts over fourteen days produced fragments only. If each drop carries not just data but emotional resonance — the feeling that something was completed — then catching single drops without the context of what they belong to gives you the feeling without the form. You had the joy. You didn't have the story it was attached to."

"Until today," Natalia said, looking at the notebook.

Wren looked at it too. The three full stories on those pages had something the fragments hadn't — they had weight. They felt like they were going somewhere. They felt, she thought, not unlike what the rain contained: like something that would be worth finishing.

She recapped her pen, looked at the ceiling, and made a decision she could feel in her whole chest.

"I want to finish one," she said. "All the way to the end."

Chapter 10 — Writing to the Last Word

They stayed in the Rainroom Nook for the rest of the afternoon.

This was not something any of them planned. It was simply what happened when a story is in the process of being completed by someone who has been trying for fourteen days and has finally found the current: you don't leave. You hold the space. You keep the rain falling and the canopies tilted and the low table clear of everything except what the writer needs.

What Wren needed was not much. A pen, a notebook, the four-catcher system running every twenty minutes or so when she needed a new direction, and the knowledge that people were in the room.

That last one surprised her to discover about herself.

"I didn't know I needed company," she said, during a break between two chapters of the story she was writing — a story about a girl who lived in a house made of cloud-stuff and learned to share her knowledge of where the solid parts were. "I've been writing alone for two years. I thought that was just what writing was."

"Sometimes it is," Maya said. "But sometimes you need witnesses. Not to watch. Just to — be there. So the act of creating feels like it's happening in a world with other people in it."

"SPARK is a witness too," Natalia said, loyally.

"SPARK is an excellent witness," Maya agreed.

"Thank you," said SPARK. "I am also recording this session for my own reference, with Wren's permission."

"Yes," Wren said, without looking up. Her pen was moving steadily. "That's fine."

They ran two more four-catcher sequences during the afternoon. One gave Wren the exact quality of light she needed for a scene she'd been trying to write for days — not golden light, not gray light, but the specific color of light that happens when the sun is behind a cloud and everything goes very temporarily equal, no shadows, everything seen plainly. The other sequence gave her an ending.

She stopped when SPARK delivered it — the quiet resolution, a girl at the edge of a foggy floor with her hand held out, the other person stepping toward it — and she sat still for a moment with the pen not moving.

"That's it," she said. "That's the end."

Alana said nothing. Natalia said nothing. Maya said nothing. Even SPARK was quiet, in the particular way it was quiet when it understood that the moment did not require commentary.

Wren wrote the last sentence. She wrote slowly, the opposite of how she'd written the rest, savoring each word the way you eat the last piece of something.

She wrote the period.

She closed the notebook.

Chapter 11 — The Rain Responds

For approximately three seconds after Wren closed the notebook, nothing happened.

Then the room did something none of them had seen before.

The rain stopped.

Not gradually — all at once, mid-fall, as if someone had turned off a tap. Every column of water simply ceased, and the drops that had been in the air finished landing and then there was just the sound of drips from soaked ferns and the quiet collection running along the drainage channels at the base of the wall.

Then the ceiling exhaled.

That was the only word Maya could find for it afterward: exhaled. As if the stone had been holding a breath, and the breath released. And with the exhalation came a different kind of moisture — not rain, not mist, but something finer, warmer, carrying no fragments, no story ideas, no whispered beginnings. Just a feeling that moved through all of them at once, clear and particular.

Completion. The specific joy of something finished and whole.

It lasted about ten seconds. Then the rain began again, gentle and silver, exactly as before.

Wren was looking at the ceiling with an expression that Maya recognized — not surprise exactly, because it fit too well with everything else. More like confirmation. Like arriving at an answer you had almost worked out from the other direction.

"It knew," Wren said.

"The room knew you finished," SPARK confirmed. Its readings were all running in parallel, capturing everything. "The pause in precipitation coincided exactly with the moment you wrote the final mark on the page. The temperature shifted point six degrees and returned to baseline. The ceiling stone registered a — I am going to call it a resonance, because that is the closest available term — a resonance consistent with what it registered in the moment just before each new column of rain begins."

"Like a reset," Alana said.

"Like a beginning," Maya corrected.

Natalia put her hand out into the rain again, experimentally. She got a cascade of fragments — a tree made of wound clocks, a fisherman who collected borrowed time, a harbor where ships returned even when lost. She shook the water off with a grin. "Still going," she reported. "Still full of ideas."

"Of course it is," Wren said. She had reopened her notebook — not to the finished story, but to a blank page near the back. "Because somewhere, right now, other people are finishing other books. In other rooms. In other libraries." She looked around the curved walls, the moss-heavy shelves, the tilted glass canopies. "And their joy is going somewhere."

She put her pen to the page.

"And now," she said, "a little bit of mine is too."

Chapter 12 — What Stays in the Nook

The sisters found their way back to the main labyrinth corridors in the late afternoon, when the light in the high clerestory windows had gone amber and the shadows between shelves had deepened to something comfortable rather than dark.

Wren came with them as far as the watercolor map at the entrance to her section. She had her notebook tucked under one arm and ink on both hands now, and she stood at the edge of the nook's hidden door with the expression of someone deciding how to say something.

"You can come back," she said finally. It came out more direct than she'd probably intended. "If you want to catch rain again. I'm usually here on Tuesdays and Thursdays. I might — it would be easier, I think. With the four-catcher system."

"Easier to write?" Natalia asked.

"Easier to be here," Wren said, which was a different answer and a braver one.

Maya smiled. "We'll be here."

SPARK emitted a small affirmative tone that translated, more or less, to yes, definitely, this is recorded in my schedule.

They walked back through the library's long afternoon, past shelves of cartography and natural history and an entire wing dedicated to books that had won awards for being impossible to categorize. The Labyrinth Library hummed around them — not loudly, not even quite audibly, but there in the way that living things are there: present, particular, warm with the accumulated business of being itself.

"The rain being made of tears," Natalia said, after a while. "That's the most beautiful thing I have ever heard, and I refuse to be embarrassed about saying that."

"You shouldn't be," Alana said.

"Someone finishes a book," Maya said, half to herself, still thinking it through, the way she thought about things she wanted to hold carefully. "And they feel that thing — that deep, earned joy. And the joy goes somewhere. It doesn't disappear. It cycles. It becomes the next writer's beginning."

"That is," SPARK said, "a very accurate description of how stories propagate through communities over time. Happiness at an ending generates energy that enables new beginnings. This has been documented in—"

"SPARK," Natalia said.

"Yes?"

"Just let it be beautiful for a minute."

SPARK was quiet for exactly sixty seconds. Then: "Beautiful. That was one minute."

Natalia laughed. Alana shook her head fondly. Maya looked back toward the hidden door — invisible now, just wall, just books, the nook folded back into the library like a secret it was content to keep until the right person needed it.

Somewhere behind that wall, rain was falling, gentle and full of stories, patient as libraries always are. Waiting for the next writer who needed to be found.

THE END